

BE WITH THE FLOWERS

Written by

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1 EXT. LONG RURAL PATH, SHIVALIK HILLS - DAY 1

In the lush hills of rural Northern India, on a riverside dirt path, ESHA (26) trudges along. She wears a messy ponytail and dirty 90s hiking gear that sticks to her skin. She lugs a massive pack, breathing heavily. She wipes her wet brow, then furrows it.

Stopping to look around while rolling out her shoulder, Esha is hypnotized by the vivid rolling hills and sparkling river. A low VOCAL RAGA echoes. When the voice fades, she rouses.

Then, she produces a neatly-folded map from one pocket and a compass from the other. She carefully unfolds the map and looks at the compass. The needle spins wildly. She shakes it roughly, then waits. Nothing. With a huff, she stuffs the objects away.

Her face twists as she struggles with her backpack straps, attempting to readjust the weight. Then, she shuts her eyes, drops her shoulders and tries to calm her breathing. She focuses on the sound of her breath, in and out. Then, her eyes snap open, and with a brief exhale, she begins stomping down the path again.

2 EXT. LONG RURAL PATH - DAY 2

Esha kneels by the river and swishes her empty bottle down into the water. Then, she takes out an iodine tablet and plops it in. She watches the tablet sizzle.

3 EXT. LONG RURAL PATH - DAY - LATER 3

Esha wears a look of exhaustion. She drags herself forward, each step heavier than the last. Suddenly, she crumples to her knees, completely spent.

She finds herself on a flat, grassy patch. She loosely surveys the area before deciding to shrug off her pack. She releases a long-held breath, wipes her forehead, then looks to the river in front of her.

Esha pulls out her water bottle and takes a big gulp, but her face twists at the taste. She spits it out and gags. After composing herself, she rises on unsteady legs and unbuckles her pack. She tugs out her tent.

4 EXT. CAMPSITE - NIGHT 4

Esha sits cross-legged inside her open tent. Her clothes are fresh, her hair is slick, and her face is clean.

She scarfs down some dried nuts, and they stick to her mouth. She looks at her empty bottle and frowns.

Then, Esha moves toward her backpack. From it, she pulls out the iodine tablets, a flashlight, a field notebook, a flimsy daypack, and four clear specimen jars. She neatly sets each item out in front of her.

Two of the jars are labelled in pen. One is a sedge sample (SHV-WP2-SDG-CYP-01 |16/6/93| ES), the other is soil (SHV-WP2-SOIL-01|16/6/93| ES). She inspects them, then pulls out her map and spreads it on the ground.

A few water bodies are circled and numbered, and her trail has been marked in red. She traces the trail with her finger and stops on a mountain. She looks up to search the horizon for it, but it's nowhere to be found.

Esha begins to massage her temples; she squints and looks at the water bottle again. Then, she exhales and grabs her daypack. In it, she packs the water bottle, tablets, notebook, flashlight, and a specimen jar inside.

Esha rises, leaving the map on the floor, and zips up the tent. As she laces up her boots, she notices the moon's reflection on the water.

5

EXT. THE WOODLANDS - NIGHT

5

In a large field, with a few trees scattered about, Esha holds her flashlight and walks with purpose. Her scientific gaze is trained on the moving ground. She stops abruptly.

Noticing paw prints in the flattened grass, her face lights up. She follows them carefully but quickly, until they turn into dirt prints. Then, she looks up to find that they lead into a dense patch of trees.

She hesitates for a moment, trying to see beyond the treeline. Then, steps over the threshold.

6

EXT. THE FOREST - NIGHT

6

Surrounded by darkness, Esha's flashlight only illuminates the ground in front of her. She continues to follow the dirt tracks, looking up occasionally to take in the forest. It seems to expand.

Her light catches a hibiscus that makes her double-take. She pores over the plant for a moment, but keeps walking. Then, the paw prints stop abruptly. Her face drops.

She looks back up at the looming forest, and her heart rate quickens. She shuts her eyes and tries to listen to her breath. Instead, a woman's voice tickles her ears, singing an alluring VOCAL RAGA. It causes Esha's shoulders to drop and her face to soften.

Suddenly, she hears a branch SNAP behind her, and the raga is replaced by the faint sound of RUSHING WATER. The sound spurs her into action. She spins to locate its direction, then follows it excitedly. Her speed picks up as the sound gets louder.

Esha narrowly dodges a jutting root before stepping into a stream and wetting her boots. Now following the stream through the forest, she tries to weave through a gap between two trees, but trips and falls onto her knees.

She winces, noticing a little scrape, but brushes off the dirt and picks herself up. When she finally straightens, her mouth falls agape.

7

EXT. THE LOTUS POND - NIGHT

7

Esha finds herself in a clearing. The stream cascades down into a silvery pond with dozens of lotus flowers on its surface. The pond glows bright enough to illuminate the space.

She switches off her flashlight. Then, seeing nothing else, takes careful steps toward the pond. She reaches the edge, and her fascinated gaze falls upon the flowers. She sits down, wearing a soft smile, then unzips her bag to grab her notebook.

A pencil marks a blank page. Next to it is a detailed sedge diagram. She picks up the pencil, and confident strokes begin to form a lotus.

Suddenly, a BUSH RUSTLES across the pond and Esha is thrust back into reality. Her eyes find the rushing stream, and there's a look of recognition. She stuffs away the notebook and grabs her bag and water bottle.

Her spine straightens, and she makes for the stream. She holds her open bottle beneath the water and watches it impatiently until her eyes snap back to the bushes.

From them, the shadow of a woman emerges. Dressed in a simple sari, MOHINI floats forward and brushes a strand of long, silky hair off her glowy skin. Esha's eyes widen, unable to look away.

The women stare at each other until they're interrupted by a SPLASH. Esha's water bottle is overflowing. Flushing pink, Esha quickly caps the bottle and snaps her eyes back to Mohini, who stands a few meters away, smiling.

MOHINI

Hello.

Esha chooses not to respond.

MOHINI (CONT'D)

My name is Mohini.

(pause)

What is yours?

Esha squints, her eyes roam over the other woman. Mohini's smile brightens, and Esha concedes.

ESHA

I'm Esha.

(beat)

What are you doing here?

MOHINI

I live here. What about you?

ESHA

(accusatory)

I didn't think anybody lived here.

MOHINI

Well, I do.

Mohini tilts her head at Esha, waiting for an answer.

ESHA

I'm here for work.

MOHINI

You're an artist?

Esha pauses and sizes her up.

ESHA

No. I'm a wetland ecologist. A scientist. I research plant species.

MOHINI

Wow. I've never met a scientist.

Mohini smiles, impressed. Esha fights the urge to smile back, then she remembers.

ESHA

Actually, I'm on a field expedition. And I was supposed to document a few specimens, collect samples. But my compass broke and I must have taken a wrong turn somewhere.

(beat)

Now I have no idea where I am, and I really need to get back on the trail.

(beat)

Can you help me?

MOHINI

Of course I can help. I've lived here my whole life. Show me your map and I'll tell you where to go.

Esha's relief quickly turns to frustration.

ESHA

I left the map at my campsite. I can get it and bring it right back.

Mohini frowns.

MOHINI

I'm sorry, but I must sleep. I can meet you here tomorrow night.

ESHA

What about the morning?

Mohini steps closer, only a few breaths away.

MOHINI

(whispering)

Only night. Are you in a rush?

Esha loses her breath. She freezes, then submits.

ESHA

I guess not. Okay. Tomorrow night.

Mohini gives Esha a smile and a nod.

MOHINI

Sleep well, Esha.

Mohini drifts back into the trees. Esha lingers in her energy for a moment before turning to leave, too.

8 INT. ESHA'S TENT - NIGHT 8

Tucked into her sleeping bag, Esha tosses and turns. Then, with a sigh, she rolls over, feels around for her flashlight, and switches it on.

She finds her notebook, then rests the flashlight on her chest and flips through her scientific drawings. She lands on the newest page, the lotus sketch. She runs a thoughtful hand over it and exhales.

9 EXT. RIVER - DAY 9

Half-dressed, Esha washes up in the river. Then, she plugs her nose and dunks herself under the water. She holds her breath for as long as possible until she bobs back up a few seconds later.

10 EXT. RIVERSIDE - DAY 10

Dressed in fresh clothes, with a clean ponytail, Esha kneels beside the river. Using a pocket knife, she cuts a sample off a nearby sedge, then puts it into a specimen jar.

She reaches into her pack, rips a piece of tape, then sticks it to the jar. With a marker, she labels it (SHV-UNM-SED-ELE-01 | 17/6/93 | ES).

11 EXT. THE WOODLANDS - DAY 11

Esha sits on a rock, eating a granola bar. She sees a squirrel scurry between the trees, then perks up. She breaks off a piece of the bar and throws it out in front of her, watching expectantly.

12 EXT. FOREST EDGE - DAY 12

Esha leans against a tree trunk, reading a book. She glances up at the pink sky.

13 EXT. FOREST - NIGHT 13

With a bounce in her step and a flashlight in hand, Esha winds through the forest, keeping her eyes on the stream.

She's almost made it to the pond when an angelic voice reverberates through the forest, singing a ROMANTIC THUMRI. Esha is drawn forward, magnetized. She stops right before the clearing and peeks through the trees.

Mohini sits with her feet in the pond, staring at her reflection and singing to the flowers. Esha stays hidden and listens patiently until the last note rings out.

14

EXT. THE LOTUS POND - NIGHT

14

Esha quietly reveals herself. Mohini doesn't look up at her, but smiles as if sensing her. Esha approaches timidly.

ESHA

I brought my map.

Mohini nods then pats the ground, motioning Esha to sit. Esha obliges and spreads out her map. She points to a part of the marked trail.

ESHA (CONT'D)

The last time I knew where I was,
it was about here.

(pointing)

Now, I should be somewhere here.

(circling an area)

But I need to end up here.

Esha pauses.

ESHA (CONT'D)

But the huge river over there isn't
mapped on this at all. Neither is
this forest.

(beat)

And this whole region has been
explored. I'm certain of that.

(beat)

So where are we?

She fixes on Mohini, expectantly.

MOHINI

I see.

Mohini softly takes Esha's hand and guides it to a point on the map. Esha stiffens at her touch.

MOHINI (CONT'D)

Instead of turning here, you should
take a left past these hills.

(beat)

So you'll need to go backwards for
a while.

Esha considers, then gives a slow nod.

ESHA
(gesturing to map)
Okay, that makes sense. But where
are we right now? And where do you
live?

MOHINI
I live here. With the flowers.

Esha tuts, shakes her head, and pulls her hand out of
Mohini's. She stands up, grabbing her map.

ESHA
(coldly)
Okay. Well thank you for the help.

Mohini slowly rises too, watching her. Esha doesn't turn to
leave yet.

MOHINI
Can I ask you a question?

Something in Esha loosens.

ESHA
Sure.

MOHINI
Why do you study flowers?

ESHA
I don't.

Mohini steps closer.

MOHINI
But you were drawing one. When I
met you.

ESHA
(dismissively)
Oh. That wasn't for work. The
flowers are just pretty. I study
plants.

They stare at the lotuses together.

MOHINI
How do you study a plant?

ESHA
Collecting samples, drawing
diagrams, tracking their growth.

Mohini looks puzzled, and Esha notices. She unhooks her bag and pulls out the specimen jar from earlier.

ESHA (CONT'D)

Like this.

Esha steps closer and hands over the jar. Mohini inspects it closely.

MOHINI

(pointing to label)

What does this mean?

ESHA

That's a labelling system.

Esha stands over Mohini's shoulder, quite close.

ESHA (CONT'D)

They're all abbreviations. SHV stands for Shivalik.

(pointing)

This one is the wetland plot number, which we always know beforehand. But here I had to write unmapped. Since I don't know where we are.

(beat)

Then it's the species, genus, and sample number. That's today's date. And those are my initials.

Mohini turns to face Esha; their faces are inches apart.

MOHINI

(softly)

Do you love it?

ESHA

Love what?

Esha's gaze flickers to Mohini's lips.

MOHINI

Your work. Your life. Plants.

ESHA

(defensively)

Of course I do.

Mohini is still. Esha lets out an aggravated chuckle.

ESHA (CONT'D)

What? You don't believe me?

MOHINI
No, it's not that.

ESHA
(annoyed)
Then what is it?

MOHINI
It is not something I can tell you.

ESHA
You don't make any sense. You think
something's wrong with *me*?

Mohini opens her mouth to speak, then doesn't. Esha scoffs.

ESHA (CONT'D)
Alright then. Good night.

Mohini stays quiet, causing Esha to turn and leave. As she
into the darkness, her lip quivers. Esha takes a last look at
the pond, which glows dimmer than before. Mohini is unmoving.

15 EXT. CAMPSITE - DAY 15

Esha staggers out of her tent wearing pajamas. Her eyes are
half closed as she raises her arms in a stretch.

16 EXT. CAMPSITE - DAY 16

Now dressed, Esha kneels and pulls a tent peg from the
ground. The tent collapses.

17 EXT. CAMPSITE - DAY 17

Esha carefully packs the last of her belongings and buckles
her pack closed. Then, she grabs the straps and heaves it
onto her thigh before swinging it onto her back. She shuffles
the weight around, then sets off.

18 EXT. LONG RURAL PATH - DAY 18

Dragging her feet, Esha plods down the path she came on. She
stares forward emptily as she walks and walks. Then, she
purse her lips, spins around quickly, and heads back to her
campsite.

19 EXT. EMPTY CAMPSITE - DAY

19

Using her pack as a backrest, Esha whittles a stick. The setting sun bounces off the river. After a finishing touch, Esha blows off the sawdust and inspects her work. Then, she raises it to her mouth and blows. It WHISTLES.

20 EXT. THE LOTUS POND - NIGHT

20

Esha sits alone with her feet in the water. She watches the flowers dance. She leans forward to caress a petal, then gently spins the lotus away.

Noiselessly, Mohini appears behind her.

MOHINI

I knew you would come back.

Esha brightens. Her hopeful eyes remain on the pond.

ESHA

How did you know?

Esha tenses as Mohini sits next to her.

MOHINI

Because you need to be with the flowers.

Esha dares to look at Mohini. They stare, eyes twinkling.

ESHA

Thank you.

Esha finally relaxes.

MOHINI

Let's swim.

Unreservedly, Mohini steps into the glowing water, fully clothed. Now neck-deep, she motions for Esha to join. Esha is surprised, but nervously steps in too.

She awkwardly wades toward Mohini, but once Esha gets close enough to touch her, Mohini dunks herself under the water. Then, she grabs Esha's legs and pulls her under too.

They begin to horseplay like children. There's a flurry of SPLASHES and LAUGHTER. The lotuses spin around. They pause to catch their breath, close enough to see the water drip off each other's smiling faces.

Then, Mohini's smile fades, and her gaze intensifies. Esha clenches her jaw. She leans in, pauses, then gives Mohini a soft kiss.

Esha pulls away, but Mohini leans in and returns the kiss. It begins gently but quickly becomes hungry. As their hands travel over each other, streaks of silver are left behind on their skin. They become completely covered in it. Mohini's hands undo Esha's ponytail. They both emanate light.

21 EXT. THE LOTUS POND - NIGHT

21

The pair lies on the ground, in each other's arms. Esha fights to keep her eyes open while Mohini plays with her wet hair.

ESHA
I'm so tired.

MOHINI
You can sleep here tonight. Nothing
will bother us.

Half-asleep, Esha nods her head and snuggles into Mohini.

ESHA
(tired whisper)
Can you sing for me?

Mohini watches the girl for a while, then begins to sing a delicate THUMRI. Esha melts into Mohini and falls asleep.

22 EXT. LOTUS POND - DAY

22

Esha's eyes slowly flutter open. Then, she rolls over and notices that Mohini is gone. Left in her place is a specimen jar with a lotus flower inside. It's labelled (SHIV-LOTUS-1 |18/6/93| Mohini). Esha smiles so big that her eyes water.

23 EXT. LONG RURAL PATH - DAY

23

A THUMRI echoes. With her pack on, Esha strides down the path again. Her head is higher, and her hair flows in the wind. Now, she glows.

24 EXT. THE LOTUS POND - DAY

24

The jar is left on the ground, lid unscrewed, and empty.

END